



Acts 6 “A Church of Order”

Intro:

As the first church grew in Jerusalem, so did the need for order. More and more believers were being added, and this growth led to conflict because of the need for an orderly way of operating. It was through these conflicts that the Lord moved His church to establish structures and delegate functions to better serve those in need while prioritizing the church's main goal: **preaching the Word of God and making disciples**.

This week we will observe how a church of order is one that **prioritizes** the preaching of the Word, **delegates** functions, **multiplies** disciples, and **shines** as vessels of the Holy Spirit.

V.1-2

“Now in these days *when the disciples were increasing in number*, a complaint by the Hellenists arose against the Hebrews **because their widows were being neglected in the daily distribution**. And *the twelve summoned the full number of the disciples* and said, **“It is not right that we should give up preaching the word of God to serve tables.”**”

1. **Prioritizes**

What we see here is the beginning of the distinction between two different offices within the local church: that of **elder** and **deacon**. Elders, as we see clearly laid out throughout the New Testament, are called to oversee the church while devoting themselves especially to teaching and preaching the Word and to prayer (1 Timothy 3:1–7; Titus 1:5–9; 1 Timothy 5:17; Acts 20:17–28; 1 Peter 5:1–4). Deacons are called to serve the church in practical matters, such as, but not limited to, distributing to those in need, as we see modeled here (1 Timothy 3:8–13). All of this is done with the purpose of **not neglecting good works while prioritizing the greatest work we are called to as a church: preaching the Word of God for the purpose of making disciples** (Matthew 28:18–20). A church of order does not neglect its other responsibilities, but always remembers its main priority and makes sure everything else is ordered around our calling to preach the Word and make disciples. (Read: 2 Timothy 4:1–2, 1 Timothy 4:13–16, Colossians 1:28)

V.3-5

“Therefore, brothers, pick out from among you seven **men of good repute, full of the Spirit and of wisdom, whom we will appoint to this duty**. **But we will devote ourselves to prayer and to the ministry of the word.**” And what they said pleased the whole gathering, and they chose Stephen, *a man full of faith and of the Holy Spirit*, and Philip, and Prochorus, and Nicanor, and Timon, and Parmenas, and Nicolaus, a proselyte of Antioch.”

2. **Delegates**

The church of Christ is designed as a body with various members carrying out various functions (Romans 12:4–6; 1 Corinthians 12:12–27). No one member is self-sufficient. **Christ is the Head of the church**, and as we all rely on Him, He has also made us members of one body who rely on one another. No part is unnecessary; each is important and must carry out its function so that the local church can effectively fulfill its mission of making disciples. For that to happen, there must be a **delegation of responsibilities**. No one person should carry the full load. Responsibility should be distributed throughout the members of the church so that each can faithfully carry out their function. In the same way, no member should be content to have no responsibility or function while others carry the load. **We are all part of one body and all responsible before God for faithfully carrying out our role and function within the local church.** (Read Exodus 8:13–26)

V.6-7

“These they set before the apostles, and they prayed and laid their hands on them. **And the word of God continued to increase**, and **the number of the disciples multiplied** greatly in Jerusalem, and a great many of the priests became obedient to the faith.”

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3. **Multiplies**

A church that is living according to God's model for the local church—**dependent upon and prioritizing Scripture, delegating responsibility, and each member faithfully carrying out their function—multiplies.** Now, it is important to notice that the text says the number of **DISCIPLES** multiplied. The sheer number of people congregating is not what ultimately matters, but that the number of **disciples** grows and that those disciples themselves continue to grow. A disciple simply means a **student or follower**. *A disciple of Jesus is a dedicated follower of Christ, a dedicated student of His Word, and a dedicated servant within the local church.* **It doesn't matter if the number of churchgoers grows if the number of disciples does not.** As dedication to the Word of God continues to increase in the local church, the number of disciples continues to multiply. (Read: Mark 4:20, Colossians 1:5–6, Matthew 28:18–20,

V.8-15

“And Stephen, **full of grace and power**, was doing great wonders and signs among the people. Then some of those who belonged to the synagogue of the Freedmen (as it was called), and of the Cyrenians, and of the Alexandrians, and of those from Cilicia and Asia, rose up and disputed with Stephen. **But they could not withstand the wisdom and the Spirit with which he was speaking.** Then they secretly instigated men who said, “We have heard him speak blasphemous words against Moses and God.” And they stirred up the people and the elders and the scribes, and they came upon him and seized him and brought him before the council, and *they set up false witnesses* who said, “This man never ceases to speak words against this holy place and the law, for we have heard him say that this Jesus of Nazareth will destroy this place and will change the customs that Moses delivered to us.” And gazing at him, **all who sat in the council saw that his face was like the face of an angel.**”

4. **Shines**

As this orderly church grows, it is impossible for it to go unnoticed. When we allow our lives to be led by the Spirit (Galatians 5:16, 25; Romans 8:5, 14), by walking in a daily relationship with Jesus and faithfully carrying out our function within the local church, **we allow Christ to shine through us.** What the religious leaders saw on Stephen's face reminds us of what the people of Israel saw on Moses' face after he came down from Mount Sinai. Moses had spent **forty days and forty nights with the Lord**, and when he came down, his face shone because he had been speaking with God (Exodus 34:28–35). Here Stephen, a man repeatedly described as **full of the Holy Spirit**, stood before the council and they saw that “his face was like the face of an angel.” In the same way, a church that walks closely with God **in submission to His order** will shine in this sinful world. But we must always remember that **this light is not our own; it is the reflection of God's presence and work in our lives.** And this is the end goal: that we would walk so closely with God, both as individuals and as a local church, that **His work in our lives would be unmistakable**, giving Him glory and pointing others to Christ. (Read: 2 Corinthians. 4-6, Matthew. 5:14-16, Philippians. 2:14-16, Ephesians 5:8–11, 1 Peter 2:9, 2 Corinthians 3:18, John 8:12, John 12:35–36, Daniel 12:3, Proverbs 4:18),

Main Idea:

God has designed His church to function in an orderly way so that His Word is prioritized, His people faithfully serve, His disciples multiply, and His light shines before the world. Let us then analyze ourselves this week as we ask the Lord to reveal to us how we can better carry out our function within the Local church to the Glory of Christ.

Memory Verse:

“And the word of God continued to increase, and the number of the disciples multiplied greatly in Jerusalem, and a great many of the priests became obedient to the faith.”

Acts 6:7 ESV



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2. Select “Ofrenda The Well”

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